



The Ethical Operator Portfolio

Building a Sustainable, Reliable & Client-Ready Business System

UTIVA PROFESSIONAL ASSIGNMENT

ETHICS, DISCIPLINE & PROFESSIONAL GROWTH

What This Assignment Assesses

This is not a theory exercise. You are being evaluated on your ability to **analyse, design, and build** real operating systems — the kind that protect your time, income, and professional reputation.

1

Analyse

Identify ethical risks in pricing, timelines, and client communication before they become costly mistakes.

2

Design

Build structured systems that ensure consistent, reliable delivery across every client engagement.

3

Build

Produce professional documentation — SOW, communication plans, and risk policies — ready for real-world use.

4

Justify

Make and defend client decisions grounded in integrity, financial logic, and long-term sustainability.

 **Submission Format:** One professionally structured PDF document, 6 pages maximum. Estimated completion time: 6–8 hours.



Your Starting Point: The Reality Check

You are a freelance professional generating **\$5,000/month** across 5–6 active clients — executing all work yourself, with no formal systems in place. Sound familiar?

How You Currently Operate

- Accept vague client briefs without clarification
- Underprice work to secure deals quickly
- Overpromise on timelines under pressure
- Miss internal deadlines consistently
- Handle client communication reactively

The Consequences You're Already Facing

- A client delayed payment due to unclear deliverables
- You redid work because of scope misunderstanding
- You lost a repeat client through inconsistent delivery
- You feel overworked, reactive, and stretched thin

These are not bad luck — they are the predictable outcomes of operating without systems.

The New Opportunity — And the Trap Inside It

A client offers you a **\$3,000 project** with the potential for long-term work. Before you say yes, look carefully at what you're actually being offered.

● Unclear Brief

The scope of work has not been defined. You have no shared understanding of what "done" looks like — a recipe for rework and disputes.

● Unrealistic Timeline

The deadline is tight and has not been stress-tested against your actual capacity. Accepting it as-is sets you up to fail from day one.

● No Payment Structure

There is no deposit, no milestone billing, and no late payment clause. You carry all the financial risk.

● High Responsiveness Expectation

The client expects fast turnarounds and high availability — without boundaries agreed upfront, this will consume your time and energy.

Your challenge: Do you accept, renegotiate, or decline? The answer depends entirely on the systems you build in this assignment.

Role Model Insight → Operator Principles

Select **one ethical business leader** whose decisions and behaviours you respect. Study how they operate — not just what they achieved, but *how* they made decisions under pressure.

What to Extract

- 3–5 specific, practical behaviours or decisions
- The values or logic behind each behaviour
- How each translates into a personal operating rule


AI Use (Optional): Use AI to summarise leadership patterns and extract decision principles from interviews, books, or case studies about your chosen leader.

Example Output Format

Leadership Behaviour	My Operating Rule
Never overpromises delivery dates	I quote timelines with a 20% buffer built in
Walks away from misaligned clients	I decline work that conflicts with my standards
Transparent about pricing rationale	I send a pricing breakdown with every proposal

These rules become the ethical foundation for every decision you make in Steps 2–8.

STEP 2 OF 8

Client Brief Analysis & Risk Identification

Before accepting any project, you must **decode the brief** — identifying what is unclear, what assumptions are dangerous, and what could go wrong. This is your Brief Decoding Worksheet.

What is Unclear?

- Scope boundaries and deliverable definitions
- Success criteria and approval process
- Stakeholders involved in sign-off

Risky Assumptions

- Client will provide assets/feedback on time
- No additional revisions beyond stated scope
- Timeline accounts for your full workload

Financial Risks

- Delayed payment with no deposit protection
- Scope creep eroding profitability
- Rework costs eating into your margin

Operational Risks

- Missed deadlines due to over-commitment
- Reputation damage from inconsistent delivery
- Burnout from unclear boundaries



Discovery & Communication Design

Before accepting the project, you must **engage the client strategically**. A structured discovery process protects both parties and establishes you as a professional — not just a task-taker.

Discovery Call Question Framework

- **Outcomes:** "What does success look like at the end of this project?"
- **Constraints:** "Are there fixed deadlines tied to external events I should know about?"
- **Process:** "Who will review and approve deliverables, and how quickly?"
- **History:** "Have you worked with a professional on this type of project before?"

Sample Client Clarification Email

"Hi [Name], thank you for reaching out. Before I put together a proposal, I'd like to ensure I fully understand your goals. Could we schedule a 20-minute call this week? In the meantime, I've attached a brief intake form to help us both make the best use of that time. Looking forward to it."

Your deliverable must include a complete version of this email and an intake form template.

Scope of Work (SOW) Development

The SOW is the most important document in your client relationship. It eliminates ambiguity, prevents scope creep, and creates a shared standard for success. Every element below must appear in your portfolio.

1

Objectives

What business outcome is the client trying to achieve? Stated clearly and measurably.

2

Deliverables

Specific outputs you will produce — format, quantity, and version defined precisely.

3

Realistic Timeline

Dates based on your actual capacity, with buffer built in. Not what the client wants — what is achievable.

4

Revision Limits

Number of revision rounds included. Any work beyond this is billed separately.

5

Assumptions

Conditions you are relying on — e.g. client provides assets by a specified date.

6

Payment Structure

Deposit amount, milestone triggers, and final payment terms — agreed before work begins.

 **AI Use:** Use AI to draft and refine your SOW. Prompt it with your project details and iterate until the language is precise, professional, and enforceable.

STEP 5 OF 8

Payment & Risk Protection System

A professional does not rely on trust alone. Your **Payment & Risk Protection System** is a set of non-negotiable policies that guard your income and define the boundaries of every engagement.

Deposit Requirement

Require 30–50% upfront before work begins. This filters out low-commitment clients and protects your time investment.



Milestone Billing

Break payment into stages tied to deliverable completion — not calendar dates. Keeps cash flow predictable.



Late Payment Clause

Define a grace period and a daily or weekly penalty rate for overdue invoices. State it clearly in your SOW.

Scope Creep Clause

Any work outside the agreed SOW requires a written change order and additional fees before execution.



Cancellation Policy

Define what happens if the client cancels mid-project. Which payments are retained? What is returned?

Consistency & Delivery System

Reliability is not a personality trait — it is a **system**. Your delivery system ensures that every client receives the same standard of work and communication, regardless of how busy or pressured you are.

Core System Components

01

Structured Workflow

Map your standard process from brief to delivery. Every project follows the same stages, preventing things from slipping through.

02

Predictable Timeline Management

Use a capacity planner to block time before committing to deadlines. Never accept work that conflicts with existing commitments.

03

Weekly Client Communication

Send a structured update every week — even when there is little to report. Silence breeds client anxiety and reactive check-ins.

Weekly Status Update Template

Subject: [Project Name] — Weekly Update

Completed this week:

- [Deliverable or milestone achieved]

In progress:

- [Current task and expected completion]

Awaiting from you:

- [Any assets, approvals, or feedback needed]

Next milestone: [Date and description]

This template is a required deliverable in your portfolio submission.

Financial & Decision Analysis

Before making your final decision on the \$3,000 project, you must run the numbers. **Revenue alone is not the metric** — risk-adjusted value is.

Risk of Accepting Without Structure

- Scope grows unpaid → effective rate drops below minimum
- No deposit means no protection if client disappears
- Missed deadlines damage reputation beyond this one client
- Time cost of rework eliminates profit margin

Revenue vs Risk Trade-Off

- \$3,000 gross $\neq$ \$3,000 net after rework and delays
- Opportunity cost: what other work could this time produce?
- Long-term potential only materialises with a healthy first engagement

Reputational Impact Analysis

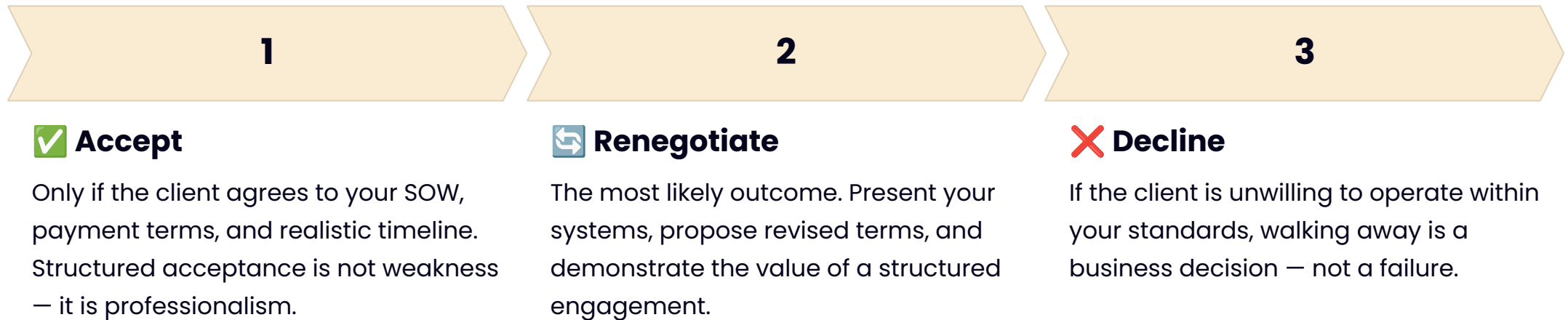
- Losing this client with dignity preserves your standards
- Delivering poorly destroys referral potential
- A renegotiated agreement signals professionalism

Your portfolio must include a written financial risk analysis that quantifies these trade-offs using real numbers and logical reasoning — not vague statements.

STEP 8 OF 8

Final Decision & Justification

This is the culmination of everything you have built. Your decision — **Accept, Renegotiate, or Decline** — must be justified using the systems, financial analysis, and ethical principles you have developed throughout this portfolio.



Your justification must reference: (1) the systems you created, (2) the financial logic from your risk analysis, and (3) your long-term sustainability as an ethical operator.

Your Complete Portfolio: 8 Required Deliverables

Your submission must be a single, professionally structured PDF of **no more than 6 pages**. Every deliverable below must be included, structured, and ready for real client use — not theoretical descriptions.

01

Role Model → Operating Principles

Leadership behaviours translated into your personal operating rules.

03

Discovery Questions + Client Email

A question framework and a professional clarification email, ready to send.

05

Payment & Risk Policy Framework

Deposit, milestone billing, late payment, scope creep, and cancellation policies.

07

Financial Risk Analysis

Quantified trade-off analysis of accepting, renegotiating, or declining the project.

02

Brief Decoding Worksheet

Structured breakdown of risks, assumptions, and unknowns in the client brief.

04

Scope of Work (SOW) Document

Complete SOW covering objectives, deliverables, timeline, revisions, and payment.

06

Weekly Status Update Template

A reusable communication template for consistent client updates.

08

Final Decision Statement

Your reasoned decision with justification grounded in systems, finance, and ethics.

The Shift: From Task-Doer to Ethical Operator

This assignment is not about completing eight tasks. It is about making a **fundamental shift in how you see yourself** — and how clients see you.

Before: The Freelancer

- Reacts to client demands
- Prices based on fear of losing work
- Operates without documentation
- Feels overworked and undervalued
- Business depends on luck and goodwill

After: The Ethical Operator

- Leads clients through a structured process
- Prices based on value and sustainability
- Operates with documented systems and policies
- Feels in control and professionally respected
- Business is built on systems, not survival

Sustainability, integrity, and long-term career health are not aspirational ideals. They are the direct result of building the right systems — and having the discipline to operate within them, every single time.